

Ordinals and Typed Lambda Calculus

Lambda Calculus

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Introduction

Alonzo Church (1903 – 1995)[†]



[†]Figures from [History of computers](#), [Wikipedia](#) and [MacTutor History of Mathematics](#).

Introduction

Some remarks

- A formal system invented by Church around 1930s.
- The goal was to use the λ -calculus in the **foundation** of mathematics.
- Intended for studying **functions** and **recursion**.
- Computability model.
- A free-type functional programming language.
- λ -notation (e.g. anonymous functions and currying).

Application, Abstraction and Curryfication

Application

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Abstraction

'If M is any formula containing the variable x , then $\lambda x[M]$ is a symbol for the function whose values are those given by the formula.' (Church 1932, p. 352)

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Abstraction

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Curryfication

'Adopting a device due to Schönfinkel, we treat a function of two variables as a function of one variable whose values are functions of one variable, and a function of three or more variables similarly.' (Church 1932, p. 352)

Lambda Terms

Definition

Let V be a denumerable set of variables. The set of **λ -terms**, denoted by Λ , is inductively defined by

$$x \in V \Rightarrow x \in \Lambda \quad \text{(variable)}$$

$$M, N \in \Lambda \Rightarrow (M N) \in \Lambda \quad \text{(application)}$$

$$M \in \Lambda, x \in V \Rightarrow (\lambda x.M) \in \Lambda \quad \text{(\(\lambda\)-abstraction)}$$

Lambda Terms

Remark

Usually, the set of λ -terms Λ is defined by the abstract grammar[†]

$\Lambda \ni t ::= x$	(variable)
$ tt$	(application)
$ \lambda x.t$	(λ -abstraction)

[†]See, e.g. (Pierce 2002).

Lambda Terms

Notation

The symbol ' $\equiv$ ' denotes the syntactic identity.

Conventions

- λ -term **variables** will be denoted by $x, y, z, \dots$.
- λ -**terms** will be denoted by $M, N, P, Q, \dots$.

Lambda Terms

Conventions and syntactic sugar

- Outermost parentheses are not written.
- Application has higher precedence, that is,

$$\lambda x. M N := (\lambda x. (M N)).$$

- Application associates to the left, that is,

$$M N_1 N_2 \dots N_k := (\dots ((M N_1) N_2) \dots N_k).$$

- Lambda abstraction associates to the right, that is,

$$\begin{aligned} \lambda x_1 x_2 \dots x_n. M &:= \lambda x_1. \lambda x_2. \dots \lambda x_n. M \\ &:= (\lambda x_1. (\lambda x_2. (\dots (\lambda x_n. M) \dots))). \end{aligned}$$

Lambda Terms

Example

Using the conventions and syntactic sugar.

$(\lambda x y z. x z (y z)) u v w$	
$\equiv (\lambda x y z. (x z) (y z)) u v w$	(left-associative application)
$\equiv ((\lambda x y z. (x z) (y z)) u) v w$	(left-associative application)
$\equiv (((\lambda x y z. (x z) (y z)) u) v) w$	(left-associative application)
$\equiv (((\lambda x y z. ((x z) (y z))) u) v) w$	(application higher precedence)
$\equiv (((\lambda x. \lambda y. \lambda z. ((x z) (y z))) u) v) w$	(right-associative λ -abstraction)
$\equiv (((\lambda x. \lambda y. (\lambda z. ((x z) (y z)))) u) v) w$	(right-associative λ -abstraction)
$\equiv (((\lambda x. (\lambda y. (\lambda z. ((x z) (y z))))) u) v) w$	(right-associative λ -abstraction)
$\equiv (((((\lambda x. (\lambda y. (\lambda z. ((x z) (y z))))) u) v) w)$	(remove outermost parentheses)

Binding

Definition

A variable x occurs **free** in M if x is not in the scope of λx . Otherwise, x occurs **bound**.

Definition

The **set of free variables in** M , denoted by $FV(M)$, is inductively defined by

$$FV(x) \quad := \{x\},$$

$$FV(M N) \quad := FV(M) \cup FV(N),$$

$$FV(\lambda x.M) \quad := FV(M) - \{x\}.$$

Substitution

Definition

The result of **substituting** N for every free occurrence of x in M , and changing bound variables to avoid clashes, denoted by $M[x \mapsto N]$, is defined by (Hindley and Seldin 2008, Definition 1.12)

$$x[x \mapsto N] := N;$$

$$y[x \mapsto N] := y, \quad \text{if } y \neq x;$$

$$(PQ)[x \mapsto N] := P[x \mapsto N]Q[x \mapsto N];$$

$$(\lambda x.P)[x \mapsto N] := \lambda x.P;$$

$$(\lambda y.P)[x \mapsto N] := \lambda y.P, \quad \text{if } y \neq x \text{ and } x \notin \text{FV}(P);$$

$$(\lambda y.P)[x \mapsto N] := \lambda y.P[x \mapsto N], \quad \text{if } y \neq x, x \in \text{FV}(P) \text{ and } y \notin \text{FV}(N);$$

$$(\lambda y.P)[x \mapsto N] := \lambda z.P[x \mapsto N][y \mapsto z], \quad \text{if } y \neq x, x \in \text{FV}(P) \text{ and } y \in \text{FV}(N);$$

where in the last equation, the variable z is chosen such that $z \notin \text{FV}(NP)$.

Substitution

Example

$(y (\lambda v. x v)) [x \mapsto (\lambda y. v y)] \equiv y (\lambda z. (\lambda y. v y) z)$ (with $z \neq v, y, x$).

Conversion Rules

Introduction

The functional behaviour of the λ -calculus is formalised through of their conversion rules:

$$\lambda x.N =_{\alpha} \lambda y.(N[x \mapsto y]) \quad (\alpha\text{-conversion})$$

$$(\lambda x.M) N =_{\beta} M[x \mapsto N] \quad (\beta\text{-conversion})$$

$$\lambda x.M x =_{\eta} M \quad (\eta\text{-conversion})$$

Alpha Congruence

Definition

A **changed of bound variables** in M is to replace a subterm $\lambda x.N$ of M by $\lambda y.(N[x \mapsto y])$ where y does not occur in N .

Definition

A λ -term M is **α -congruent** with N , denoted by $M \equiv_{\alpha} N$, iff N results from M by a finite (perhaps empty) series of changes of bound variables.

Example

Whiteboard.

Alpha Congruence

Theorem

The relation $\equiv_\alpha$ is an equivalence relation.[†]

Convention

Following Barendregt ([1981] 2004, Convention 2.1.12), we syntactically identified λ -terms that are α -congruent, that is,

$$M \equiv N := M \equiv_\alpha N.$$

[†]See, e.g. (Hindley and Seldin 2008, Lemma 1.19b).

Compatible Relations

Definition

A binary relation R on Λ is **compatible** iff[†]

$$(M, N) \in R \quad \Rightarrow \quad \begin{cases} (P M, P N) \in R, \\ (M P, N P) \in R, \\ (\lambda x.M, \lambda x.N) \in R. \end{cases}$$

[†]See, e.g. (Barendregt [1981] 2004, Definition 3.1.1i).

Beta Reduction

Definition

The binary relation β on Λ is defined by

$$\beta := \{ ((\lambda x.M) N, M[x \mapsto N]) \mid M, N \in \Lambda \}.$$

Beta Reduction

Definition

The binary relation **one step β -reduction** on Λ , denoted by $\rightarrow_\beta$, is the compatible closure of β .

The $\rightarrow_\beta$ relation can be inductively defined by[†]

$$\frac{(M, N) \in \beta}{M \rightarrow_\beta N}$$
$$\frac{M \rightarrow_\beta N}{P M \rightarrow_\beta P N} \quad \frac{M \rightarrow_\beta N}{M P \rightarrow_\beta N P} \quad \frac{M \rightarrow_\beta N}{\lambda x. M \rightarrow_\beta \lambda x. N}$$

[†]See, e.g. (Barendregt [1981] 2004, Definition 3.1.5).

Beta Reduction

Definition

The binary relation **β -reduction** on Λ , denoted by $\rightarrow_\beta$, is the reflexive and transitive closure of $\rightarrow_\beta$.

The $\rightarrow_\beta$ relation can be inductively defined by[†]

$$\frac{}{M \rightarrow_\beta M} \qquad \frac{M \rightarrow_\beta N}{M \rightarrow_\beta N} \qquad \frac{M \rightarrow_\beta N \quad N \rightarrow_\beta P}{M \rightarrow_\beta P}$$

[†]See, e.g. (Barendregt [1981] 2004, Definition 3.1.5).

Beta Equality or Beta Convertibility

Definition

The binary relation **β -equality** (or **β -convertibility**) on Λ , denoted by $=_\beta$, is the equivalence relation generated by $\rightarrow_\beta$.

The $=_\beta$ relation can be inductively defined by[†]

$$\frac{M \rightarrow_\beta N}{M =_\beta N}$$
$$\frac{M =_\beta N}{N =_\beta M} \qquad \frac{M =_\beta N \quad N =_\beta P}{M =_\beta P}$$

[†]See, e.g. (Barendregt [1981] 2004, Definition 3.1.5).

Normal Forms

Definition

A **β -redex** is a λ -term of the form $(\lambda x.M) N$.

Definition

A λ -term which contains no β -redex is in **β -normal form** (β -nf).

Definition

A λ -term N is a **β -nf of M** (or **M has the β -nf M**) iff N is a β -nf and $M =_{\beta} N$.

Example

Whiteboard.

Normal Forms

Remark

Church (1935, 1936) proved that the set

$$\{ M \in \Lambda \mid M \text{ has a } \beta\text{-normal form} \}$$

is not computable[†] (i.e. undecidable). This was the **first** undecidable set ever.[‡]

[†]We use the term ‘computable’ rather than ‘recursive’ following to (Soare 1996).

[‡]See also (Barendregt [1990] 1992).

Combinators

Definition

A **combinator** (or **closed λ -term**) is a λ -term without free variables.

Convention

A combinator called for example `pred` will be denoted by `pred`.

Combinators

Example

Some common combinators.

$B := \lambda f g x. f (g x)$

(a composition combinator)

$B' := \lambda f g x. g (f x)$

(a reversed composition combinator)

$C := \lambda x y z. x z y$

(a permuting combinator)

$I := \lambda x. x$

(an identity combinator)

$K := \lambda x y. x$

(a projection combinator)

$M := \lambda x. x x$

(a doubling combinator)

$S := \lambda f g x. f x (g x)$

(a stronger composition combinator)

$T := \lambda x y. y x$

(a permuting combinator)

$V := \lambda x y z. z y x$

(a permuting combinator)

$W := \lambda f x. f x x$

(a doubling combinator)

Combinators

Remark

The programs in a programming language based on λ -calculus are combinators.

Remark

The combinators K and S (i.e. the combinatory logic) are a Turing-complete language.

Fixed-Point Combinators

Definition

A **fixed-point combinator** is any combinator fix such that for all terms M ,

$$\text{fix } M =_{\beta} M (\text{fix } M).$$

Theorem

The combinator $Y := \lambda f. V V$, where $V \equiv \lambda x. f (x x)$, is a fixed-point combinator.[†]

Theorem

The combinator $U U$, where $U := \lambda u x. x (u u x)$, is a fixed-point combinator.[‡]

[†]According to (Hindley and Seldin 2008, p. 36), this combinator was hinted by Curry in 1929 and first published by Rosenbloom (1950). See also (Barendregt [1981] 2004, Corollary 6.1.3).

[‡]Defined by Turing (1937). See, also (Barendregt [1981] 2004, Definition 6.1.4).

Recursion Using Fixed-Points

Example

An informal example using the factorial function (Peyton Jones 1987, § 2.4.1).

$\text{fac} := \lambda n. \text{if } (n == 0) \text{ then } 1 \text{ else } n * \text{fac } (n - 1)$	(combinator)
$\equiv \lambda n. (\dots \text{fac } \dots)$	(recursive combinator)
$\equiv (\lambda f. \lambda n. (\dots f \dots)) \text{ fac}$	(λ -abstraction on fac)

Recursion Using Fixed-Points

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$$\begin{aligned}\text{fac} &:= \lambda n. \text{if } (n == 0) \text{ then } 1 \text{ else } n * \text{fac } (n - 1) && \text{(combinator)} \\ &\equiv \lambda n. (\dots \text{fac} \dots) && \text{(recursive combinator)} \\ &\equiv (\lambda f. \lambda n. (\dots f \dots)) \text{fac} && \text{(\lambda-abstraction on fac)}\end{aligned}$$

Now, we can redefine the factorial function using `fix`.

$$h := \lambda f. \lambda n. (\dots f \dots) \quad \text{(non-recursive combinator)}$$

$$\text{fac} := \text{fix } h \quad \text{(fac is a fixed-point of h)}$$

(continued on next slide)

Recursion Using Fixed-Points

Example (continuation)

$$\begin{aligned}\text{fac } 1 &\equiv \text{fix } h \ 1 \\ &=_{\beta} h \ (\text{fix } h) \ 1 \\ &\equiv (\lambda f. \lambda n. (\dots f \dots)) (\text{fix } h) \ 1 \\ &\rightarrow_{\beta} \text{if } (1 == 0) \text{ then } 1 \text{ else } 1 * (\text{fix } h \ 0) \\ &\rightarrow_{\beta} 1 * (\text{fix } h \ 0) \\ &=_{\beta} 1 * (h(\text{fix } h) \ 0) \\ &\equiv 1 * ((\lambda f. \lambda n. (\dots f \dots)) (\text{fix } h) \ 0) \\ &\rightarrow_{\beta} 1 * (\text{if } (0 == 0) \text{ then } 1 \text{ else } 1 * (\text{fix } h \ (-1))) \\ &\rightarrow_{\beta} 1 * 1 \\ &\rightarrow_{\beta} 1\end{aligned}$$

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